

BONUS RESOURCE

The Outlook Inbox-Zero Playbook

Templates to tame email, draft replies and stay ahead of your inbox every day

- 60+ copy-paste prompts for triage, replies, summaries and follow-through
- The reframe that matters most: Copilot's real value is reading fast, not writing fast
- A daily and weekly rhythm that keeps the inbox from refilling overnight
- Setup for priority inbox, draft instructions and rules, plus a troubleshooting page

Current as of September 2026. Assumes Microsoft 365 Copilot in Outlook on the web, new Outlook for Windows, Mac, iOS or Android.

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1 Set up before you triage

Five settings that make everything after this page work better

Copilot in Outlook is two jobs wearing one badge: Summarise and Draft. Most people are shown Draft first and decide the whole thing is overrated after one bland reply. Summarise is the one that actually changes how your day feels - fix the setup below, and section 2 will make the case.

Check	What to do and why it matters
Licence and client	Requires a Microsoft 365 Copilot licence. Full feature set is on Outlook on the web, new Outlook for Windows, Mac, iOS and Android - classic Outlook for Windows lags behind.
Priority inbox	Outlook Settings -> Copilot -> Prioritize. Turn it on and add plain-language rules for what matters, such as "emails about [project] are always high priority." It only affects mail that arrives after you turn it on.
Draft instructions	Outlook Settings -> Copilot -> Draft instructions. Set your default tone and length once so every draft starts closer to your voice instead of generic corporate register.
Rules in plain language	Copilot can create and explain Outlook rules from a natural-language request, so "move anything from this list into this folder" no longer needs the classic rules wizard.
Shared mailboxes	Copilot's coverage of shared and delegated mailboxes trails behind your own inbox. Check what is actually supported before you build a workflow around one.

Teach yourself Summarise before Draft. Draft is the feature everyone demos. Summarise is the one that makes a forty-message thread cost ten seconds instead of ten minutes - and that is the habit that actually keeps an inbox from piling up.

2 Read fast: the summarise-first habit

The unglamorous feature that actually changes your day

Your inbox does not pay you to read. It pays you to decide. Every thread you have to reconstruct before you can act on it is a small tax, paid over and over. Summarise removes the reconstruction step, so triage stops feeling expensive enough to defer.

"Summarise this thread: the decisions made, who owns what, and any dates mentioned."

"What does this email actually need from me? One sentence."

"Summarise everything in this thread I have not replied to yet."

"Has anyone already answered the question in this email further down the thread?"

"Summarise this email in the sender's own tone - are they asking, telling, or escalating?"

Once summarising takes ten seconds, triage stops being an afternoon block and starts happening in the gaps between meetings. That shift, not a faster reply, is the actual productivity gain.

3 Triage prompts by inbox state

Matched to the situation you are actually in when you open Outlook

Different inbox states need different prompts. These are grouped by the situation you are actually in when you open Outlook, not by feature name.

THE 200-UNREAD MONDAY

"Prioritize my unread emails from the last three days and tell me which five need a reply today."

"Group my unread emails into: needs a decision from me, FYI only, and safe to archive."

"Which unread emails are from someone outside my organisation, and what does each one want?"

"Find any email in my unread list that looks time-sensitive but is not marked urgent."

THE THREAD YOU GOT CC'D INTO

"Summarise this thread and tell me whether anything in it actually requires my input."

"Has my name been mentioned anywhere in this thread? If so, what was asked of me?"

"This thread has forty messages. Give me only the last decision made and what happens next."

THE INBOX YOU ARE BEHIND ON

"List every email from this week I have not replied to, oldest first, with one line on what each one needs."

"Which senders have emailed me more than once this week without a reply from me?"

"Draft a single holding reply I can send to everyone I am behind on, acknowledging the delay and giving a day I will respond properly."

CLEARING THE NOISE

"Find newsletters and automated notifications in my inbox from the last 30 days that I have never opened, and list them so I can unsubscribe or filter them."

"Which emails in my inbox are calendar invites or responses that are already resolved and safe to archive?"

4 Draft prompts by situation

A real brief in, a first pass out - never a finished email

Draft is at its best with a real brief, not a vague instruction. Give it the outcome, the tone and the length, and treat the result as a first pass you edit, not a finished email.

QUICK REPLIES

"Draft a friendly reply confirming we'll deliver by Friday. Under two paragraphs."

"Reply saying yes to this request, and ask for one clarifying detail: [detail]."

"Draft a polite decline for this invitation, no explanation needed beyond being unavailable."

"Reply acknowledging this email and telling them I'll have a full answer by [day]."

HARDER REPLIES

"Draft a reply that pushes back on this deadline, explains why, and proposes [alternative date], in a tone that is firm but not defensive."

"Draft a reply that says no to this request without sounding dismissive. Keep it to three sentences."

"This email is frustrated. Draft a reply that acknowledges that directly before addressing the issue."

"Draft a reply that corrects a misunderstanding in this thread without making anyone look bad."

FROM SCRATCH

"Draft an email to [name] asking for [what you need], with context on why, in under 150 words."

"Draft a status update to [name/team]: what shipped, what is blocked, what is next. Keep it scannable."

"Draft an introduction email connecting [person A] and [person B], with one line of context on why they should talk."

"Draft a follow-up to a meeting with no reply yet, referencing what we discussed without sounding like a nag."

TOPE AND LENGTH CONTROL

"Make this draft warmer without making it longer."

"Cut this draft to half the length without losing the ask."

"Rewrite this so the ask is in the first sentence, not the last."

"This reads too formal for a colleague I know well. Loosen it up."

5

Coach before you hit send

Save it for the email where the wording actually matters

Coaching by Copilot reviews a draft for tone, clarity and likely reception before you send it - useful on anything where the wording actually matters. Apply suggestions individually rather than all at once if the draft is already close to right.

- "How is this email likely to land? Flag anything that could read as terser or colder than I intend."*
- "Is the ask in this email clear? Tell me if a busy reader could miss it."*
- "Check this for anything that sounds passive-aggressive, even if that is not the intent."*
- "Is this email longer than it needs to be? Point to what could be cut."*
- "Read this as the recipient would. What would their first reaction be?"*

Coach is most valuable on the email you have rewritten three times and still are not sure about - not on routine replies. Save it for the one where the stakes or the relationship make the wording worth a second opinion.

6

Rules and inbox prioritisation

A few minutes of setup that pays off every day after

The setup work in section 1 pays off here. These two features run continuously in the background, so a few minutes spent teaching them well saves triage time every single day after.

- "Create a rule that moves any email from [sender or domain] straight into [folder]."*
- "Show me all my current Outlook rules and explain what each one does in plain English."*
- "Create a rule that flags any email with [keyword] in the subject as high priority."*
- "Find rules I have that conflict with each other or that no longer make sense given how I work now."*

GETTING PRIORITISATION RIGHT

Teach it what matters	"Emails about [project] are always high priority" or "anything from my manager is always high priority" - plain language, added directly in Prioritize settings.
It only applies going forward	Turning on prioritisation does not re-sort what is already in your inbox. Run a manual triage pass once, then let it take over.
Low priority is not spam	A low-priority tag means Copilot judged it non-urgent, not irrelevant. Skim low-priority mail in a batch rather than ignoring it entirely.

7 The daily 15-minute rhythm

Three short passes beat one inbox left open all day

Fifteen minutes, twice a day, beats an inbox left open and glanced at all day. This is the rhythm the prompts above are built to support.

Morning - 8 minutes

Prioritize my unread emails from overnight and tell me which need a reply today. Then clear anything marked safe to archive or already resolved.

Before lunch - 3 minutes

Summarise anything new since this morning that looks time-sensitive. Reply to the two or three that are quick; leave the rest for the afternoon block.

End of day - 4 minutes

List every email from today I have not replied to, and draft holding replies for anything I cannot properly answer until tomorrow.

The goal is not zero unread. It is zero undecided. An email you have read, judged, and deliberately deferred is not clutter - it is a decision already made.

8 The weekly reset

Fifteen minutes that stops small drift becoming a backlog

The daily rhythm keeps the inbox from growing. This is the fifteen minutes that stops small drift from becoming a backlog.

1 Find what is stuck

"List every email older than five days that I have not replied to, with the reason it is still open." Some of these need action; some no longer matter.

2 Close what no longer matters

For anything that has resolved itself or gone stale, archive it without a reply rather than letting it sit as a guilt-inducing unread.

3 Batch the real backlog

"Draft replies for these five emails" and work through them together while you are already in reply mode, rather than one at a time all week.

4 Check what is training your priority inbox

Ask what got marked high priority this week and whether that still matches what actually mattered. Adjust the instructions in Prioritize settings if it drifted.

5

Clear the noise sources

Revisit the newsletter and notification prompt from section 3. Unsubscribe from anything you skipped every time this week.

9

When it does not work

Symptoms, causes and fixes

Most Outlook Copilot frustration traces back to one of these, not to the model being wrong.

Symptom	Almost always the cause
Draft sounds generic	No draft instructions set, or the prompt gave no tone or length. Set a default in Copilot settings and give specific instructions per email.
Priority tags feel off	The plain-language rules in Prioritize settings need tuning - they are a starting point, not a fixed algorithm. Add or edit instructions as you notice misses.
Nothing happens in a shared mailbox	Copilot's feature coverage in shared and delegated mailboxes is narrower than your own inbox. Check what is supported before building a workflow around one.
Summarise misses older messages	Very long threads may summarise only the most recent portion. Ask specifically for the earlier part if the context you need is further back.
Feature is missing entirely	Classic Outlook for Windows trails new Outlook, web and mobile on feature availability. Confirm which client you are on before assuming a feature does not exist.
Language detection did not trigger	Automatic language detection in Summarise is not yet available on every platform. State the language you want explicitly if it guesses wrong.

QUICK REFERENCE

The Outlook Inbox-Zero Playbook

TRIAGE

- Prioritize my unread emails and tell me which need a reply today
- Summarise this thread: decisions, owners, dates
- What does this email actually need from me? One sentence.
- Which unread emails are safe to archive?

DRAFT

- Draft a reply confirming/declining/asking for [x], in [tone], under [length]
- Make this warmer / shorter / more direct
- Draft a holding reply acknowledging delay, answer by [day]

BEFORE YOU SEND

- How is this likely to land? Flag anything colder than I intend
- Is the ask clear to a busy reader?

KEEP IT RUNNING

- Teach Prioritize: "[project/person] is always high priority"
- Create a rule that moves [sender] to [folder]
- Weekly: list emails older than 5 days I have not answered, with why

Inbox zero was never really about the number. It is about never having an email sitting there that you have read but not decided on. Summarise gets you to a decision fast. Draft carries it out. The rhythm keeps it from ever piling back up.